



Mirror

User Guide

Dead-simple drag-and-drop file backup for macOS

Version 1.0.3

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1 Welcome to Mirror

Mirror keeps your files safe by copying a source folder to one or more destinations — an external drive, a network volume, or any folder on your Mac. There is no complicated setup: drop a folder on each side, press **Sync now**, and watch it happen with real-time progress and clear reporting.

Mirror was built for people with large, precious libraries — photos, video, music projects, documents — who want a backup they can actually see and verify, without learning command-line tools.

Requirements

- macOS 14.0 Sonoma or later (including macOS 26 Tahoe), Apple Silicon or Intel.
- Full Disk Access is recommended so Mirror can reach every file: **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security** → **Full Disk Access**.

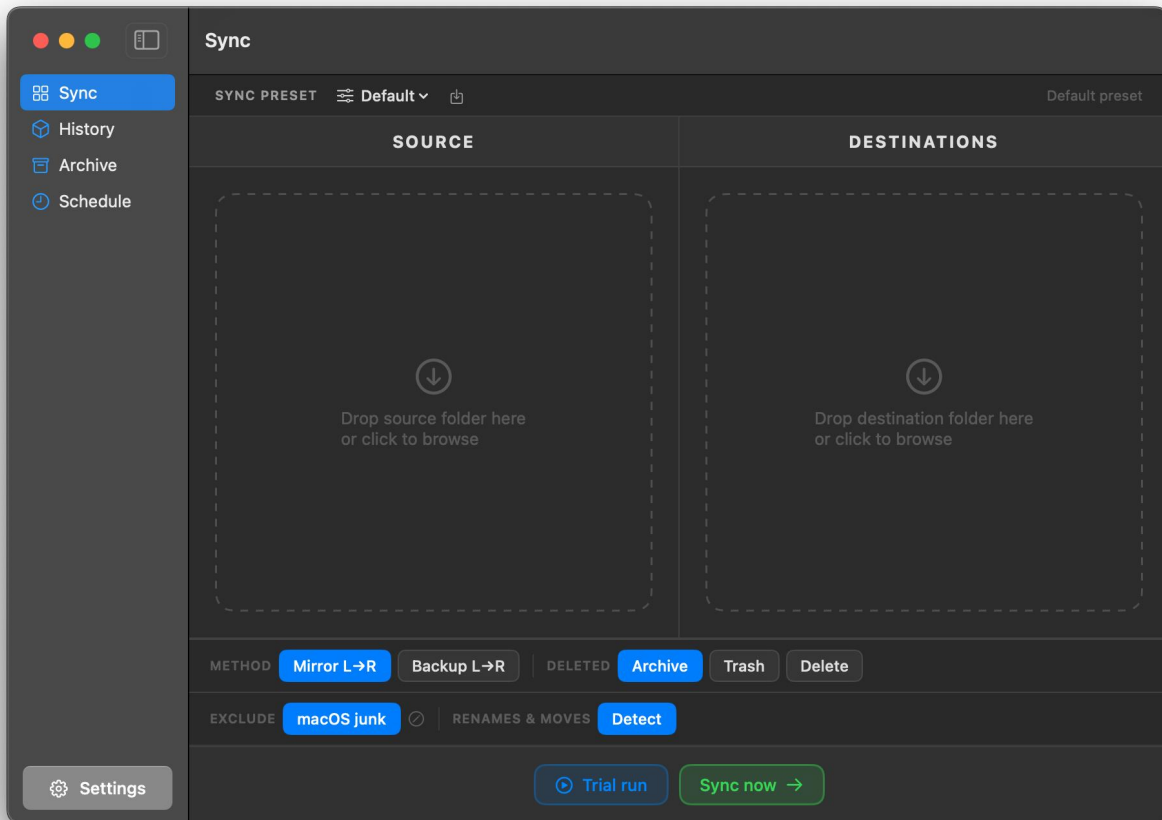
Installing

- Download the latest release and unzip it.
- Drag **Mirror.app** into your Applications folder and open it.

Privacy

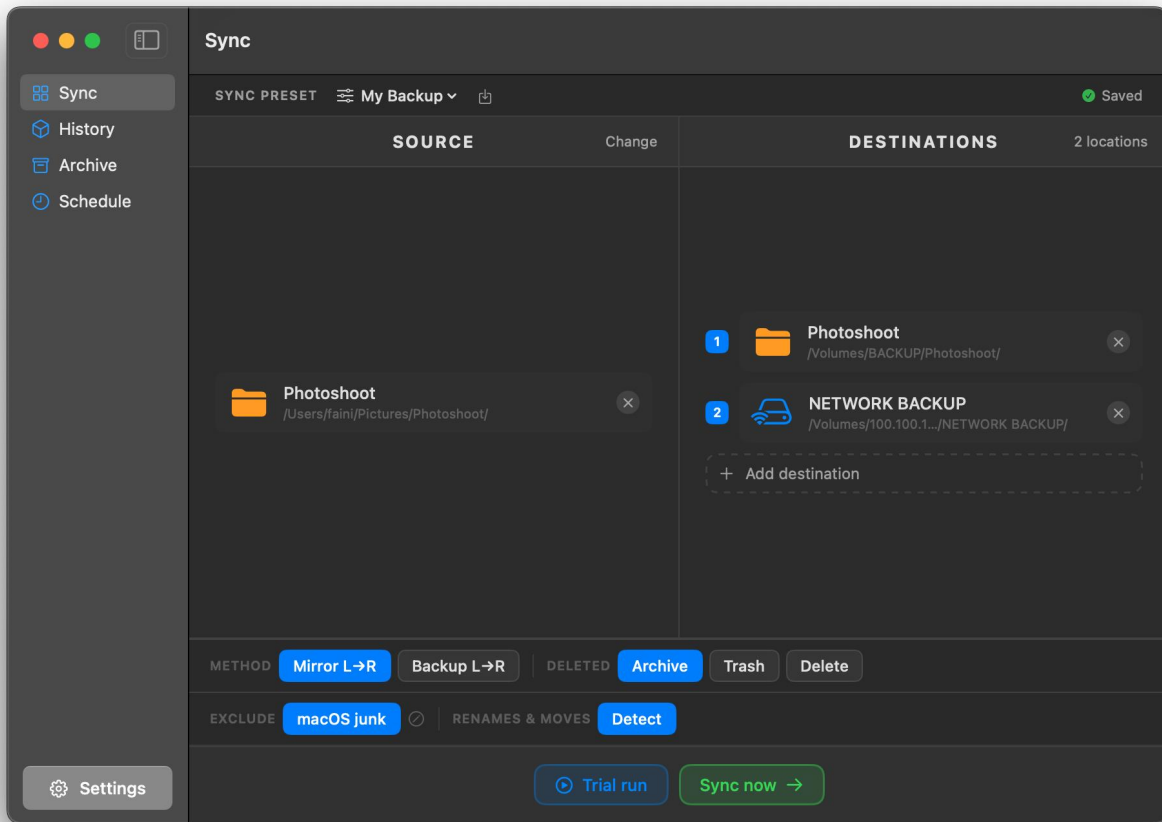
Mirror runs entirely on your Mac — your files are never sent to any server. The only network requests are a silent update check on launch and license activation with the payment provider.

2 Your First Sync



The Sync page when you first open Mirror — two drop zones, ready to go.

- **Add a source.** Drag the folder you want to protect into the left panel, or click it to browse.
- **Add one or more destinations.** Drag a folder on an external drive, a network volume, or your Mac into the right panel. Click **Add destination** to back up to several places at once — Mirror can copy to two or more drives at the same time to maximize throughput.
- **Choose your method** (Mirror or Backup — see the next section) and how deleted files are handled.
- **Click Trial run** to preview exactly what will happen, then **Sync now** (or press ⌘↵) to run it.



A configured task: one source syncing to an external drive and a network volume.

Presets

The current source, destinations, and options are saved as a **sync preset** (the selector at the top of the Sync page). Create a preset per job — say, “Photos → Backup drive” and “Documents → NAS” — and switch between them instantly. Presets are also what schedules and automation run.

3 Sync Methods & Deleted Files

Method	What it does	Best for
Mirror L→R	Makes the destination an exact copy of the source. New and changed files are copied; files that no longer exist in the source are removed from the destination.	A true backup that always matches the source.
Backup L→R	Additive: new and changed files are copied, but nothing is ever removed from the destination.	Collecting files over time, e.g. offloading cards or accumulating exports.

What happens to removed files (Mirror method)

- **Archive** (default) — removed files are kept in a recoverable, in-app archive. Deleted doesn't mean gone.
- **Trash** — removed files go to the macOS Trash. The Trash isn't available on network volumes (NAS / SMB shares) and some non-Apple filesystems — removals on those destinations automatically fall back to **Archive**, so nothing is ever lost or left behind.
- **Delete** — removed files are deleted immediately.

Rename & move detection

Renamed a folder of 50 GB of photos? With **Renames & Moves: Detect** enabled, Mirror recognizes that the files already exist at the destination and updates them in place instead of re-copying. A reorganization that would otherwise re-transfer the whole shoot becomes a few seconds of instant moves — and the files keep their place on the destination rather than being deleted and written again. Most backup tools can't do this at all.

Mirror never guesses. A destination file is only treated as renamed when it has gone missing from its old path on the source and matches on size and modification date — and its contents are confirmed before anything moves. Small files, and any case where several destination files share the same size, are compared byte-for-byte in full. Larger files are confirmed by size, date, and matching content sampled from the beginning, middle and end. A file simply moved to another folder under the same name is matched on size and date, exactly as Mirror decides any file is unchanged. **If a match cannot be confirmed for any reason — including a file that can't be read — Mirror copies it fresh instead.**

Tip: after reorganizing a large library, run a **Deep verify** (Section 6). It reads every byte on both sides and confirms the destination is bit-for-bit identical — certainty rather than confidence, whenever you want it.

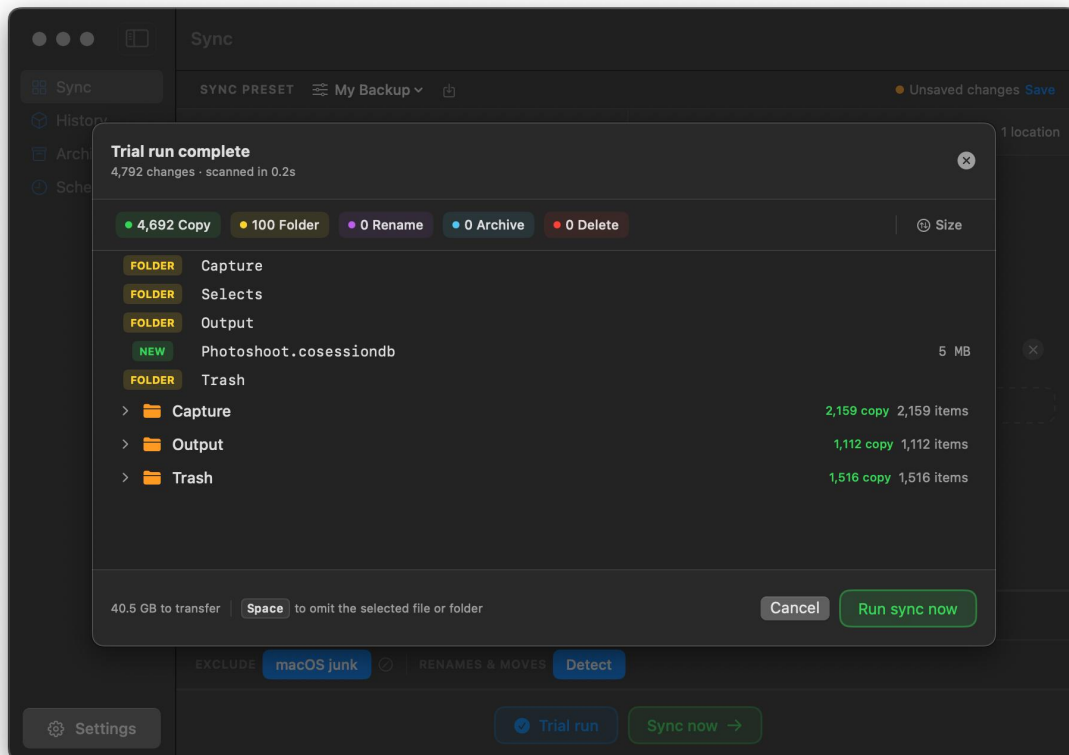
Exclusions

- macOS system junk (.DS_Store, Spotlight indexes, resource forks...) is always excluded.
- Transient database journal files (e.g. Capture One's .cosessiondb-journal, Lightroom's .lrcat-wal) are excluded by default — they vanish mid-sync and can corrupt a catalog if restored next to a database they don't match.
- Add your own exclusion patterns in Settings: exact names, prefixes, or wildcards such as *.tmp.

4 Trial Run — Preview Before You Sync

A trial run scans everything and shows the complete plan — what will be copied, moved, renamed, archived, or removed, per destination — before a single file is touched. It stays fast and responsive even with tens of thousands of changes.

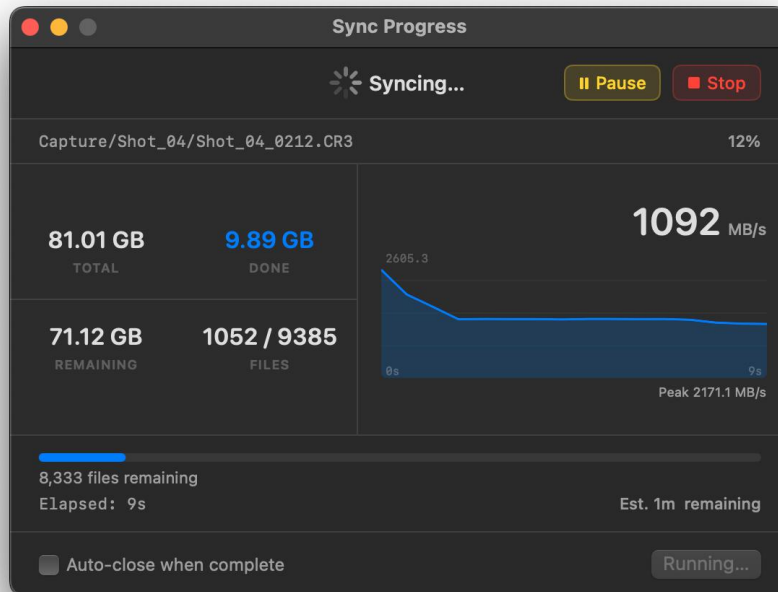
While it runs you see the current phase and live counts. A trial only reads, so you can **Cancel** at any point — nothing is left half-done. Press ⌘T any time to run one; before a first big sync — or any sync that removes files — it is the best habit you can build.



Every planned change, grouped by folder, with totals and the data to transfer.

- The colored chips at the top summarize the plan: copies, new folders, moves, renames, archives, and deletions. **Click a chip to filter** the list to just that kind of change — click it again to show everything.
- Select any file or folder and press **Space** to omit it from this run.
- Syncing to multiple destinations? Each gets its own tab. **Right-click a destination's tab and choose "Ignore for this sync"** to skip that destination entirely — handy when one backup drive isn't connected. It's automatically included again on your next sync.
- If a sync would remove a large share of a destination — or the source scanned as empty — a warning appears right here in the preview, so surprises never wait until you press Sync.
- Happy with the plan? Click **Run sync now** straight from the preview. Curious where the time went? Hover the "scanned in ..." line for a per-phase breakdown.

5 Watching a Sync



Live transfer speed, files completed, data remaining, and time estimate.

While a sync runs you see the current file, a live speed graph with the peak rate, how much data is done and remaining, and an estimated time to finish.

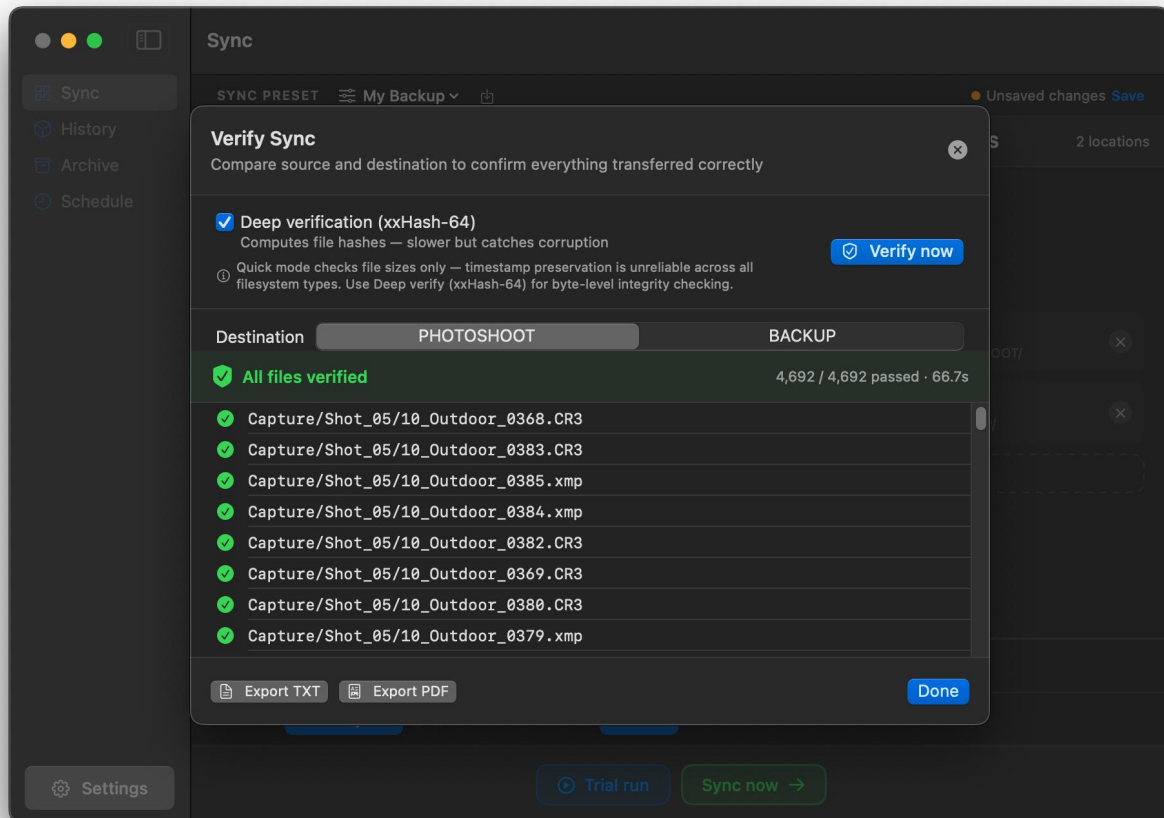
- **Pause / resume** (⌘P) — pause a sync and pick it up later.
- **Stop** (⌘.) — stop safely at any point. Thanks to atomic copies, a stopped sync never leaves a destination file half-written.
- Interrupted large file transfers **resume where they left off** — the existing partial file is validated against the source before Mirror appends to it.
- A notification tells you when the sync completes, with the result.

Built-in safety

- **Pre-flight check** — each destination is verified reachable and writable before anything starts, and disk space is checked so you're warned if a destination may not have room.
- **Atomic copies** — a destination file is replaced only after the new copy is fully written and flushed, so a failed sync can't damage the previous version.
- **Removal safety guard** — if the source scans as empty (usually an unmounted drive) or a sync would remove a large share of a destination, Mirror stops and asks first. Scheduled runs refuse automatically and notify you instead. Renamed or moved files are kept in place and aren't counted as removals, so reorganizing your library never looks like a mass deletion.

6 Verification — Trust Your Backup

A backup you haven't verified is a hope, not a backup. After any sync, Mirror can compare the destination against the source and prove they match.



Deep verification: every file checked, per-destination results, exportable report.

- **Quick** — compares file sizes. Fast, catches missing or truncated files.
- **Deep (xxHash-64)** — computes a hash of every file on both sides: a bit-for-bit integrity check, optimized to stay fast on large photo and video libraries.

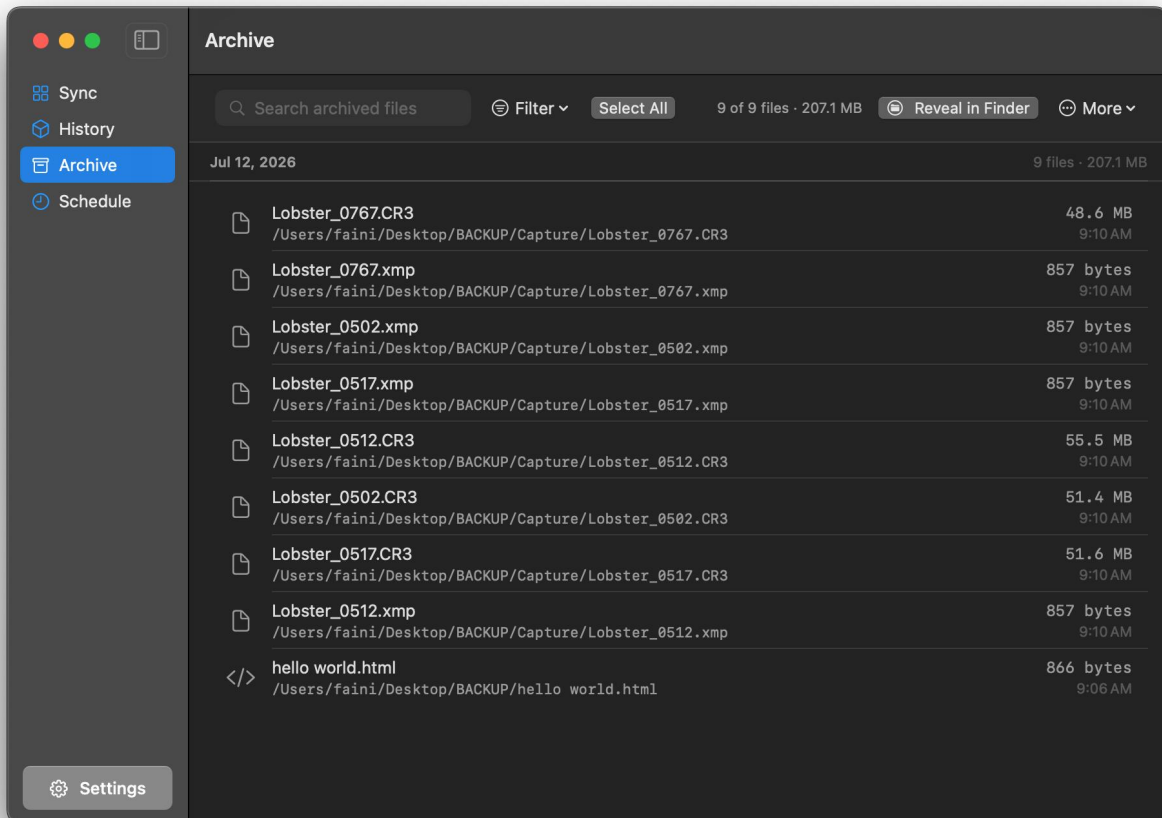
Run verification manually after a sync, or turn on auto-verify after every sync in Settings. Results are recorded in History and can be exported as TXT or PDF — handy when a client or your own peace of mind wants proof.

Verifying a Backup L→R task? Backup mode never removes anything from a destination, so files that exist only there are expected. Verification checks that every source file arrived intact, but doesn't flag destination-only files as “extra” — they're kept by design, not an error.

Why not timestamps? Timestamp preservation is unreliable across filesystems (network volumes especially), so Mirror's deep verify relies on content hashes instead.

7 The Archive

With the **Archive** option selected, files removed by a Mirror sync aren't gone — they're kept in a browsable, searchable archive inside the app.

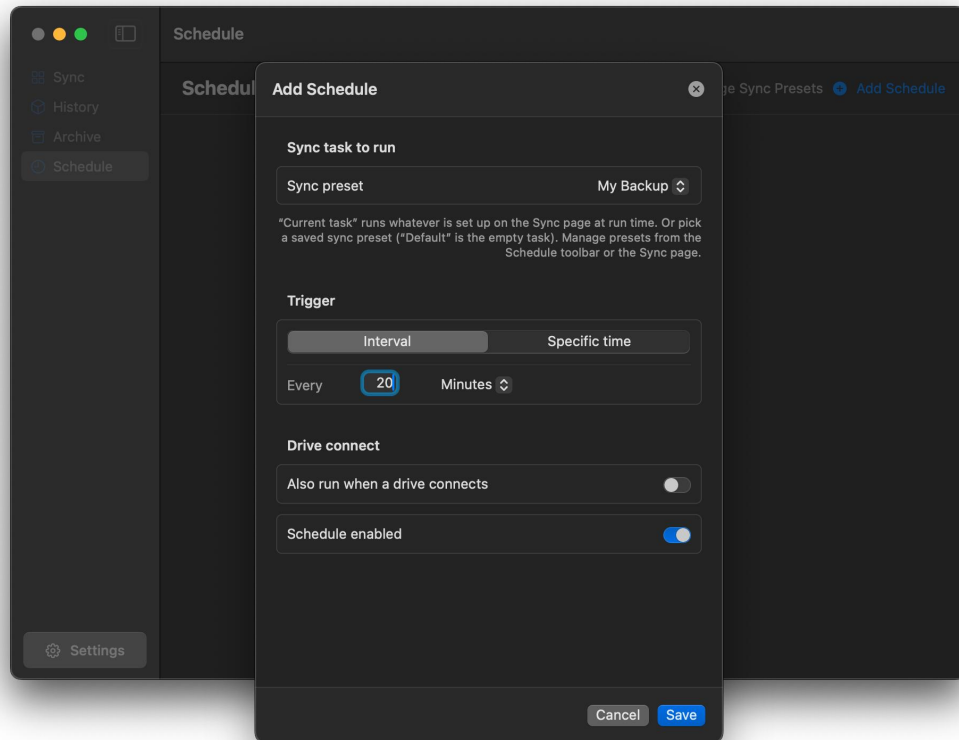


The Archive: search, filter, select, and restore — grouped by the sync that archived them.

- Browse and search everything a sync has ever archived, grouped by date.
- Restore a single file or many at once — the original folder structure is preserved.
- Syncing to multiple destinations? Browse each destination's archive separately or all together.
- **Reveal in Finder** jumps straight to the archived file on disk.

8 Scheduling

Backups you have to remember aren't backups. Schedules run a saved preset (or the current task) automatically, and you can create several independent schedules.



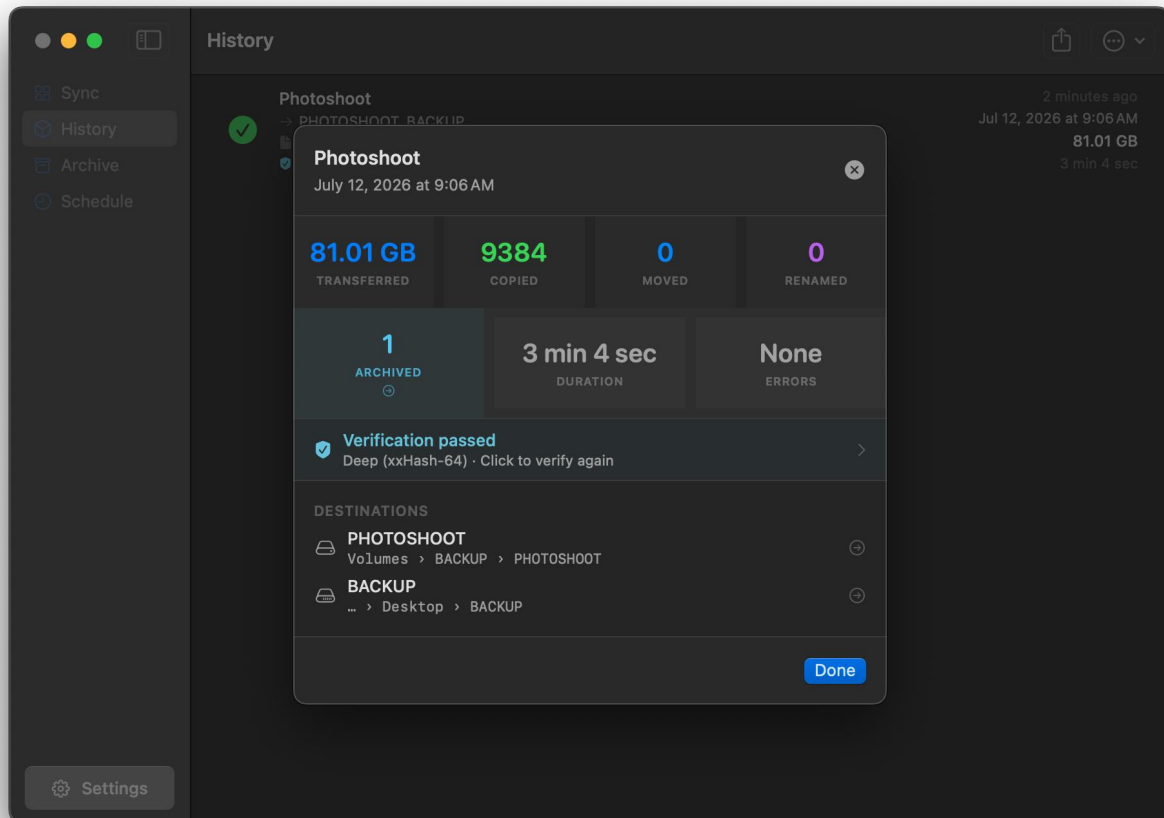
Adding a schedule: pick a preset, then an interval, a specific time, or a drive-connect trigger.

- **Interval** — every N minutes or hours.
- **Specific time** — at set times on the days you choose.
- **Drive connect** — run automatically the moment a backup drive is plugged in.
- **Run in the background** — turn on **Run scheduled syncs in the background** on the Schedules page and scheduled syncs run without opening the progress window or interrupting what you're working on. You still get a completion notification, and live progress is on the Sync page whenever you open Mirror.
- **Keep Mirror running** — in **Settings** → **General**, turn on **Keep Mirror running when the window is closed** so closing the window leaves Mirror in the Dock and schedules keep firing. Enabling it also switches scheduled syncs to background mode automatically; click the Dock icon to reopen the window.

If your Mac was asleep or Mirror wasn't running when a schedule was due, the missed run is caught up the next time Mirror is open. Scheduled runs are protected by the removal safety guard: anything suspicious (like an unmounted source) makes the run refuse and notify you rather than touch your backup.

9 History & Reports

Every sync is recorded: file counts, transfer sizes, duration, verification results, and any errors — categorized so you can see at a glance what happened.



A sync record: totals, duration, verification status, and each destination.

- Stopped syncs show the specific reason — “Drive disconnected”, “Disk full”, “Stopped manually”.
- Click a record's verification row to re-verify that sync at any time.
- Export any record as plain text or PDF.
- History can clean itself up automatically by age or by count (Settings → History).

10 Keyboard Shortcuts & Automation

Keyboard shortcuts

Shortcut	Action
⌘T	Run trial sync
⌘⇧	Run sync now
Space	Omit the selected file or folder (Trial run window)
⌘P	Pause / resume a running sync
⌘.	Stop a running sync
⌘,	Open settings
⌘W	Close window

URL scheme

Mirror can be driven by anything that can open a URL — Shortcuts, Stream Deck, Keyboard Maestro, Alfred, Raycast, a shell script...

URL	Action
mirror://sync?preset=Name	Run sync for a preset
mirror://sync?preset=Name&silent=1	Sync without opening the window
mirror://trial?preset=Name	Run a trial sync
mirror://stop	Stop the current sync
mirror://status	Copy status JSON to the clipboard
mirror://open	Bring Mirror to the front

11 Good to Know — Limits by Design

Mirror is deliberately focused. Knowing what it doesn't do is as useful as knowing what it does:

- **One-way sync only.** Mirror copies from source to destinations — it is not a two-way/bidirectional sync tool. Changes made directly in a destination will be overwritten or removed on the next Mirror sync.
- **Folder backup, not a system cloner.** Mirror backs up folders you choose. It doesn't create bootable clones of macOS and isn't a replacement for Time Machine's versioned system snapshots — it complements them.
- **No cloud storage.** Destinations are folders your Mac can see: local disks, external drives, and mounted network volumes. (A cloud folder that syncs via a local folder, like Dropbox or Drive, works fine.)
- **Network volumes must be mounted.** Mirror can't mount a server share by itself — connect to it in Finder first (or set it to auto-mount at login).
- **The Trash needs volume support.** Most network volumes have no Trash, so the Trash option can't apply there — Mirror automatically archives those removals instead (see section 3). Restore them any time from the Archive.
- **Schedules run while Mirror is running.** Missed runs are caught up the next time the app is open — they can't fire while it's fully quit. Closing the window normally quits Mirror; turn on **Keep Mirror running when the window is closed** (Settings) to leave it in the Dock so schedules keep firing with the window shut.
- **Version history lives in the Archive.** Mirror keeps files that were removed or replaced (Archive option), but it isn't a full point-in-time versioning system with browsable snapshots per date.

12 Troubleshooting

Symptom	What's happening & what to do
"Destination not reachable" before sync	The pre-flight check couldn't see or write to the destination. Make sure the drive is connected (or the network share is mounted in Finder) and isn't read-only, then run the sync again.
Sync stopped: "Drive disconnected" or "Disk full"	Mirror stopped safely — nothing was left half-written. Reconnect the drive or free up space and re-run the sync; large files resume from where they left off.
Mirror asks before removing files (safety guard)	The source scanned as empty or the sync would remove a large share of the destination. This usually means a source drive isn't mounted or you picked the wrong folder. Check the source in Finder before confirming — only confirm if the removals are genuinely intended.
Chose Trash, but files were archived	That destination doesn't support the Trash (most network volumes don't). Mirror archives removals there instead of leaving them behind or deleting them — restore them any time from the Archive section.
A scheduled run didn't happen	Mirror must be running for schedules to fire; missed runs are caught up when you next open the app. If a run was refused, the notification and History entry explain why (usually the safety guard or an unreachable drive).
"Permission denied" or files skipped	Grant Mirror Full Disk Access: System Settings → Privacy & Security → Full Disk Access → enable Mirror, then relaunch it.
Verification reports mismatches	Run the sync again, then Deep verify. If the same files keep failing, the destination disk may be failing — try another drive and check it with Disk Utility.
Errors on catalog/journal files (e.g. Lightroom, Capture One)	These transient journal files are excluded by default. If you removed that exclusion, re-enable it in Settings — the files vanish mid-sync and are unsafe to restore anyway.
Update check or license activation fails	Both need a brief internet connection. Day-to-day use is fully offline; try again when you're online.

Still stuck? The History entry for a sync lists every error, categorized, and can be exported — include it when you get in touch via fainimade.com.

13 Trial, Licensing & Support

Free trial

Mirror includes a 7-day free trial with full functionality — every feature in this guide, no limitations.

Buying a license

- Purchase at **software.fainimade.com** — your license key arrives by email.
- To activate: **Settings** → **About** → **Enter License Key**, and paste your key.
- **One license, two Macs** — each license includes 2 seats.
- **Good for life across all 1.x releases** — every 1.x update is free.
- Moving to a new Mac? **Settings** → **About** → **Deactivate This Mac** frees a seat, then activate on the new machine.
- Activation and deactivation need a brief internet connection; day-to-day use works fully offline.

Support

For support or licensing questions, get in touch via fainimade.com.

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